This soup is for early summer when asparagus first appears and when fresh morel mushrooms are in season. It should taste fresh and light, so cooking times are brief.

asparagus and morel soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

1½ quarts (1½ liters) chicken stock
1 small potato, cut into ¾in (2cm) dice
1 small leek, rinsed, trimmed, and cut into ¾in (2cm) lengths
14oz (400g) asparagus, trimmed and cut into 2in (5cm) lengths
1 tbsp olive oil
1 tbsp crème fraîche
2 tbsp unsalted butter
salt and freshly ground black pepper
4 large fresh morels (or 4 dried morels soaked in lukewarm water for 30 minutes)

1 Heat the stock in a large saucepan, add the potato, and bring to a boil. Lower the heat and simmer for 5 minutes. Add the leek and asparagus and cook, uncovered, for 7–8 minutes. Pick out four attractive asparagus tips and reserve for garnishing. Transfer the contents of the pan to a blender and process until smooth. Add the olive oil, crème fraîche, and 1½ tbsp of the butter, then season with salt and freshly ground black pepper.

2 Halve the morels lengthwise and brush clean inside and out. Cook gently in a pan with the remaining butter for a few minutes until cooked. Meanwhile, reheat the soup. Serve garnished with the morels and reserved asparagus tips.



ASPARAGUS
Buy spears with plump, firm stems and tight buds. Organic asparagus is expensive to produce (keeping the beds weeded is a labor of love) but, for its subtle flavor of freshly cut grass, it is well worth the indulgence.